*WEST*

EDITION 2026–27



INFO BOOKLET

# For *High Schools*

*How your strongest students work on real companies for college credit, at no cost to the school.*

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WEST VENTURES · AFFILIATED WITH AUSTIN CHRISTIAN UNIVERSITY

GOWEST.VENTURES

Cover: Emanuel Leutze, Westward the Course of Empire Takes Its Way, 1861 (study).

A LETTER

# From the managing partners

Thank you for asking about West Ventures. This booklet is written for heads of school, principals, counselors and teachers.

We ask partner schools for one thing: to name their most capable students. Those students, called Builder Scholars, join teams with college students and do real work for experienced founders and operators. They earn college credit for it, with no homework and no tests beyond the work itself. The school pays nothing.

Everything in these pages is how the studio operates today. Where a detail is still being set, it says so. If something here does not answer your question, reply to the email this booklet came in and one of us will answer it.

*Jake Oswald*

MANAGING PARTNER

*Lars Ostervold*

MANAGING PARTNER

FOR HIGH SCHOOLS

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This booklet is written for high schools. Four companion booklets cover the program for parents, students, founders and executives and universities.

01 · THE STUDIO

# What West Ventures is

*A venture studio affiliated with Austin Christian University.*

West Ventures finds young people with exceptional ability, puts them to work for proven founders and operators, and builds companies with them. It does three things, and each one feeds the others.

I

## Teams

Small teams of high school and college students work on real problems for founders and operators, for academic credit. Companies pay nothing.

II

## Companies

When a project turns up an opportunity worth building, the studio builds it with the operator who found it, as a joint venture.

III

## Network

Partner high schools and universities send their best students. Founders, operators and investors bring the work.

---

**23**

Companies served by student teams so far

**78**

Students who have worked on a team

**500**

Partner schools planned by 2030

02 · THE MODEL

# Kings and *cupbearers*



GUSTAVE DORÉ, NEHEMIAH VIEWS THE RUINS OF JERUSALEM'S WALLS, 1866. NEHEMIAH WAS CUPBEARER TO THE KING.

The thesis is not tied to an industry. The studio's advantage is its model: free work, done by a large group of the country's most capable young people, for the most experienced founders and operators.

The old words for the arrangement are kings and cupbearers. Kings are proven owners and operators with more opportunities than time. Cupbearers are capable young people who need real work and someone to learn from. The studio's job is to match them, at scale.

The arrangement works because each side gets what it lacks. Founders get capable help, at no cost, on work they have no time for. Students get real work, someone to learn from and academic credit. And when a project turns up an opportunity worth building, the studio builds it with the operator who found it, as a joint venture. It expects to start about six companies a year this way.

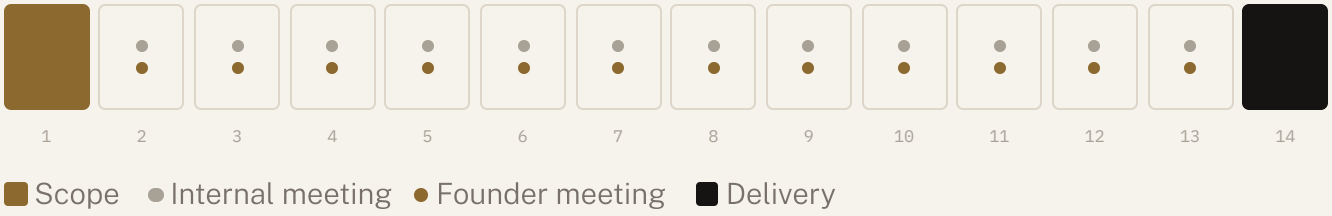
03 · HOW A PROJECT WORKS

# How a project works

*One team, one founder, one term, one written scope.*

A project is one term of work by one team, for one founder or executive. Terms run in fall, spring and summer. The founder brings a real problem and about an hour a week. The company pays nothing and keeps all equity and intellectual property. Students earn academic credit.

A FALL OR SPRING TERM




| | |
|---|---|
| *Before* | The studio matches the project with a team and a project advisor, and introduces them to the founder. |
| *Week one* | The founder and the project advisor write the scope: a week-by-week plan of what the team will deliver. |
| *Every week* | Two meetings. One internal, with the project advisor, on tasks and blockers. One with the founder, to review the work and adjust the scope. |
| *End of term* | The team delivers and hands over. The project advisor evaluates each student; the founder evaluates the project. |
| *After* | Students who delivered are invited back with more responsibility. An opportunity worth building may become a joint venture. |

04 · THE TEAM

# The team

*About five students, an experienced project advisor and the founder.*



**Two college students**, one of whom leads the team.

**Three high school Builder Scholars**, nominated by their schools.

Two roles are easy to confuse. The **team leader** is a college student who runs the team day to day. The **project advisor** is an experienced volunteer professional who coaches the team, keeps the scope honest and evaluates the work. Teams mix students from different schools on purpose, and studio staff oversee every team.

ROLES, TIME AND CREDIT

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Team leader** | College student | 5 to 10 hrs a week | 6 credit hours |
| **Contributor** | College student | 4 to 8 hrs a week | 3 credit hours |
| **Builder Scholar** | High school student | About 3 hrs a week | 3 credit hours |
| **Project advisor** | Volunteer professional | Two meetings a week | — |
| **Founder** | The company | About 1 hr a week | — |

05 · EXPECTATIONS

# What each party commits to

*The arrangement works when everyone does their part. This is what each is asked to do.*

## The school

- Name one contact who nominates students.
- Nominate two to five capable students each term.
- Let students take part alongside their coursework.

## The project advisor

- Run the weekly internal meeting and coach the team.
- Keep the scope current and the founder informed.
- Hold students to the standard the founder expects.
- Evaluate each student's work at the end of the term.

## The studio

- Recruit and screen students and project advisors.
- Match each project with a team that can deliver it.
- Handle all academic paperwork and credit.
- Oversee every team and step in when a project is off track.

## Students

- Give the hours the role requires, every week.
- Attend both weekly meetings, prepared.
- Deliver what the scope says, when it says.
- Keep the company's information confidential.
- Represent the company and the studio well.

## The founder

- Bring a real problem or opportunity that matters to the business.
- Write the scope with the project advisor in week one.
- Meet the team once a week and answer questions in between.
- Give honest feedback, including when the work falls short.
- Evaluate the project at the end of the term.

06 · CREDIT

# College credit, *no homework*

Builder Scholars earn 3 college credit hours a term through Austin Christian University for the work they do on their team. There are no tests and no assignments created for the course. Students submit evidence of the work they already produce for their founder, and their project advisor evaluates it.

The studio never creates work the founder did not ask for.

Partner schools nominate two to five students a term. The studio interviews each nominee and contacts the family. Schools pay nothing; there is no quota and no minimum.

For the fall 2026 cohort, 35 high school seniors were selected from hundreds of nominees nationwide.



VALLEY CHRISTIAN SCHOOL



THE STONY BROOK SCHOOL



OAKS CHRISTIAN SCHOOL

Partner schools include Sierra Canyon School, Santa Fe Christian Schools, Gilbert Christian Schools, Greater Atlanta Christian School, Little Rock Christian Academy, Jupiter Christian School and others.

07 · COST AND FUNDING

# Cost and funding

*Free to the school. Families pay tuition, and the school can choose to help.*

## $0

To the school. No partnership, license or per-student fee, now or later.

## $5,000

Per student, per term, paid by the family. $15,000 for a full year. Need-based scholarships are available.

HOW IT WORKS

| | |
|---|---|
| *Nominate* | The school names students it thinks are a fit. That is the whole commitment. |
| *Decide* | Each student and family decides whether to take part. No one is enrolled without choosing to be. |
| *Fund* | Tuition pays for the program: the staff who recruit and oversee every team, training for the volunteer project advisors, and academic credit. Companies are never charged. |

COVERING THE COST FOR YOUR STUDENTS

Some schools choose to pay tuition for their strongest students, for example as part of an honors program. Ways to fund it include setting aside scholarship funds, a gift from a donor who wants to back student builders, or grants for enrichment or college and career readiness. The studio can help you make the case.

08 · OUTCOMES FOR STUDENTS

# Outcomes for students

*Responsibility is earned one term at a time.*

| | |
|---|---|
| *01* | **Builder Scholar.** A high school student on a team, nominated by their school. Earns college credit. |
| *02* | **Contributor.** A college student on a team, doing a defined part of the scope. |
| *03* | **Team leader.** Invited after a strong term. Leads the team day to day and answers to the founder. |
| *04* | **Fellow.** The studio's most trusted students. Fellows work directly with proven operators on the studio's own companies, two or three at a time. |

**78**

Students who have worked on a team

**21**

Student Fellows named

**2×**

Gloo AI Hackathon won by ACU student teams, 2025 and 2026

Every student keeps a record of the work: a public profile listing each company they worked for, their role and what the team delivered, alongside academic credit on a transcript and a reference from a project advisor who saw the work.

09 · STUDENT STORIES

# Student stories

*Students don't need a business idea or a network. They need to show up and do excellent work.*

Most 18-year-olds have poor business ideas and no network. The studio has both: opportunities found by experienced operators, and the founders, executives and investors behind them. A student raises their hand, is placed on a real project, and is judged on effort, attitude and the work itself. When they deliver, their network grows and opportunities follow. Here are eight of them.



**Yakira Cardoso** · *p. 13*
TEAM LEADER · COLLEGE STUDENT

CE

**Cole Elzerman** · *p. 14*
TEAM LEADER · COLLEGE STUDENT

PG

**Preslee Gordon** · *p. 15*
TEAM LEADER · UPPERCLASSMAN IN COLLEGE

CD

**Connor Dore** · *p. 16*
BUILDER SCHOLAR · SENIOR IN HIGH SCHOOL

JE

**Jonah Elliot** · *p. 17*
FRESHMAN IN COLLEGE

BP

**Braden Peays** · *p. 18*
FRESHMAN IN COLLEGE

LC

**Lillia Caldroney** · *p. 19*
BUILDER SCHOLAR · HIGH SCHOOL STUDENT

MW

**Merci Wymore** · *p. 20*
BUILDER SCHOLAR · HIGH SCHOOL STUDENT

STUDENT STORY · 01

# Yakira Cardoso

TEAM LEADER · COLLEGE STUDENT

TO CONFIRM · YEAR IN COLLEGE



*An all-night pitch deck, a first-place finish and a seat on a founding team.*

| | |
|---|---|
| Project | Adoption Is An Option |
| Role | Team leader |
| Competition | First place, $12,000 |
| Now | Founding team, Adoption Is An Option |

Yakira joined the student team working with John Knox, a founder and philanthropist who was launching a nonprofit, Adoption Is An Option. When the students were given a chance to meet him, she stayed up all night building a pitch deck so she could bring him her own thinking about the organization he was starting.

He was impressed enough by the students, and by Yakira in particular, that he created a series of opportunities for them. One was a TikTok ad competition he funded, with $25,000 in cash prizes and ads judged only on how they performed. Yakira took first place and $12,000.

He then asked her to join the founding team launching Adoption Is An Option.

STUDENT STORY · 02

# Cole Elzerman

TEAM LEADER · COLLEGE STUDENT

TO CONFIRM · HEADSHOT

TO CONFIRM · YEAR IN COLLEGE

CE

*From waiting tables to leading a company spinning out of Life Time.*

| | |
|---|---|
| Gloo AI Hackathon | First place, 2025 and 2026 |
| Current project | Life Time |
| Result | About $1.2 million a year saved |
| Next | Helping lead the spinout |

Two summers ago, Cole was waiting tables. Since joining the studio he has won the Gloo AI Hackathon in Boulder, Colorado, two years in a row, and has worked on and led a series of projects for founders and executives.

One of the projects he leads now is for Life Time. His team built technology that is saving the company about $1.2 million a year in overhead. It is being spun out as its own company to commercialize, and Cole will help lead it.

STUDENT STORY · 03

# Preslee Gordon

TEAM LEADER · UPPERCLASSMAN IN COLLEGE

TO CONFIRM · HEADSHOT

TO CONFIRM · YEAR IN COLLEGE

PG

*Leading two teams, and hired by the founders of one of the organizations she serves.*

| | |
|---|---|
| Projects | Commissioned, Best Buddies |
| Role | Team leader on both |
| Now | Part-time role with Commissioned's co-founders |

Preslee has moved up through several projects and this fall leads two teams: one for Best Buddies, and one for Commissioned, a network of hundreds of Christian women entrepreneurs who gather each year to learn from one another.

Her Commissioned team helped put on this year's gathering. Working alongside the network's co-founders, she led the team well enough that they hired her as a paid, part-time member of their staff.

The event also introduced her to a great many women founders. She is learning to lead a team and deliver real value, and her network has grown faster than it could have any other way.

STUDENT STORY · 04

# Connor Dore

BUILDER SCHOLAR · SENIOR IN HIGH SCHOOL

TO CONFIRM · HEADSHOT

CD

*A high school senior with a paid role and a growing network.*

| | |
|---|---|
| Projects | launch.kids, The Care App |
| Focus | AI |
| Gloo AI Hackathon | Award and cash prize, 2026 |
| Now | Paid role at The Care App |

Connor is a senior in high school and a Builder Scholar. He contributes to two projects, launch.kids and The Care App, and his focus is AI. His skills have grown quickly from one project to the next.

At the 2026 Gloo AI Hackathon he competed on the Unify team, which won an award and a cash prize.

His work on The Care App led the company to offer him a paid role alongside school. Through it he was introduced to the creative director of Porsche, an advisor to the company, to work with him on using AI to build out the platform.

STUDENT STORY · 05

# Jonah Elliot

FRESHMAN IN COLLEGE

TO CONFIRM · HEADSHOT

JE

*A college freshman working as a fractional CTO.*

| | |
|---|---|
| Year | College freshman |
| Largest offer | $250,000 a year |
| Now | Fractional CTO for several companies |
| Rate | $150 an hour or more |

Jonah is a freshman in college. Through relationships made in the studio, he has had several offers to work for companies. One was for $250,000 a year.

He now works as a fractional CTO for a few companies, alongside school, and each pays him $150 an hour or more. He keeps building his skills and his network on studio projects.

STUDENT STORY · 06

# Braden Peays

FRESHMAN IN COLLEGE

TO CONFIRM · HEADSHOT

TO CONFIRM · SALE AND TERMS

BP

*A track win as a freshman, and a company sold within six months.*

| | |
|---|---|
| Company | Unify |
| Gloo AI Hackathon | Best in agentic engineering, 2026 |
| Outcome | Acquired · terms to come |

Braden came into the studio as a freshman. At the 2026 Gloo AI Hackathon he won best in agentic engineering for Unify, the company he is building with the studio: one platform for nonprofits in place of a stack of separate tools.

He was approached about an acquisition and sold the company less than six months later.

STUDENT STORY · 07

# Lillia Caldroney

BUILDER SCHOLAR · HIGH SCHOOL STUDENT

TO CONFIRM · HEADSHOT

TO CONFIRM · GRADE

TO CONFIRM · WHAT SHE HAS LEARNED AND BUILT

LC

*A high school student's first term, working for a bank.*

| | |
|---|---|
| Project | Regent Bank |
| Role | Builder Scholar |
| First term | Fall 2026 |

Lillia is a high school Builder Scholar. Her first project, this fall, is for Regent Bank, on a team led by a college student and coached by an experienced project advisor.

Working for a bank has meant learning how a regulated business makes decisions, meeting with the bank's team every week, and learning the research, writing and AI tools the team uses to do the work. It has also put her in the same room as the people who run a bank, at an age when few students meet anyone like them.

STUDENT STORY · 08

# Merci Wymore

BUILDER SCHOLAR · HIGH SCHOOL STUDENT

TO CONFIRM · HEADSHOT

TO CONFIRM · GRADE

TO CONFIRM · HER STORY SO FAR

MW

*One term in, on a team building a care app.*

| | |
|---|---|
| Project | The Care App |
| Role | Builder Scholar |
| First term | Fall 2026 |

Merci is a high school Builder Scholar. She began her first project this fall with The Care App, on a team of college students and other Builder Scholars.

Like every new student, she started with a defined part of the scope, meets with the company each week, and is evaluated on what she delivers. Students who do that well are invited back with more responsibility.

10 · FROM FAMILIES AND TEACHERS

# From families and teachers

PARENT TO BE COLLECTED

"A line from the parent of a Builder Scholar: what changed in their son or daughter over a term."

**Name**
Parent of a Fall 2026 Builder Scholar

TEACHER TO BE COLLECTED

"A line from a teacher or counselor who nominated students: why they nominated them and what came back."

**Name**
Teacher, partner high school

STUDENT TO BE COLLECTED

"A line from a Builder Scholar about the work they did and who they did it for."

**Name**
Builder Scholar, Fall 2026

STUDENT TO BE COLLECTED

"A line from a college team leader about leading a team for a founder."

**Name**
Team leader, Fall 2026

Families and teachers who would speak with a prospective family directly can be introduced on request.

11 · FROM FOUNDERS

# From founders

"Cole has been outstanding on our startup — smart, technically capable, coachable, hardworking, and a true team player. His contribution reflects not only strong technical skill, but the character, humility, and mission-minded leadership ACU is developing in its students."

Paul Kent Graeve
Founder & CEO, Today Matters

"I've spent years working in Big Tech in Silicon Valley with the world's most premiere talent. The profile of the ACU student is unique. The world has a lot of knowledge, but it needs more wisdom. ACU students are showcasing a rigorously intellectual foundation coupled with a moral, Christian fabric — a combo the world desperately needs more of. I wouldn't hesitate to bring an ACU student on."

John Kronlokken
Founder & CEO, Evergreen / Ex-Corporate Strategy, Google

"As an entrepreneur, I wish I had the college experience that ACU is creating. ACU provides students the opportunities they need to become excellent, and the students are delivering on that opportunity. Coming into the engagement, I thought it would be predominantly mentorship. I was wrong. The students delivered tangible value to our organization the whole way through. Movements like this will inspire the next generation of leaders to believe God is in all things, including our work."

Anthony Ruffner
Founder & CEO, Turn

12 · THE NETWORK

# The network



VALLEY CHRISTIAN SCHOOL



THE STONY BROOK SCHOOL



OAKS CHRISTIAN SCHOOL




SIERRA CANYON SCHOOL



SANTA FE CHRISTIAN SCHOOLS



GILBERT CHRISTIAN SCHOOLS

PARTNER HIGH SCHOOLS

Valley Christian School
The Stony Brook School
Oaks Christian School
Sierra Canyon School
Santa Fe Christian Schools
Gilbert Christian Schools
Greater Atlanta Christian School
Little Rock Christian Academy
Jupiter Christian School
Regent School of Austin
Southwest Christian High School
Cincinnati Hills Christian Academy
Linfield Christian School
Timothy Christian Schools
Silverdale Baptist Academy
Cuyahoga Valley Christian Academy

VENTURE FIRMS

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Capital Factory
Overmatch
Sovereign's Capital
Live Oak Ventures
Wave Ventures
Eagle Venture Fund
Fireroad
11 Tribes
Worldview
Waterstone Impact Fund
Mission 3A
Keystone Capital
Stackhouse Ventures
Our Appologies
Sandbox.Fund

ORGANIZATIONS

Praxis
Faith Driven Entrepreneur
Gloo
Solving
Venture Forge
Christian Economic Forum
National Christian Foundation
Impact Foundation
The Signatry
Talanton
CESA
ACSI
SeedTree Group
Schools United
Classical Conversations
Classic Learning Test

13 · QUESTIONS

# Questions

### What does it cost the school?

Nothing. Partner schools are never charged. Families pay tuition for the course, with need-based scholarships available.

### How many students can we nominate?

Typically two to five per term. There is no quota. Schools whose students deliver tend to place more of them.

### Does it interfere with school?

It should not. Builder Scholars spend about 3 hours a week, mostly in one team meeting and short tasks. There is no homework and there are no tests.

### What credit do students earn?

College credit, awarded through Austin Christian University and transferable as each receiving college decides.

### Who supervises students under 18?

Every team has an adult project advisor and is overseen by studio staff. Meetings are scheduled and online. See the Supervision section of the parents' booklet for details.

### What does the school get?

A place for its strongest students to do work at the level they are capable of, a record of that work, and recognition as a partner school.

14 · NEXT STEPS

# Next steps

*1*

## Name a contact

Reply to the email this booklet came in with the name of the person who will nominate students.

*2*

## Nominate students

Send the names of two to five students. The studio contacts each student and family directly.

*3*

## See the work

At the end of each term the school receives a summary of what its students delivered.

CONTACT

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# *WEST*

VENTURES

A venture studio affiliated with Austin Christian University.

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